

The Architecture of Connection

Evaluating the ROI of Faculty-Led Skills Coaching in Online Counseling Education

Working Draft — Prepared for Internal Review

Executive Recommendation

Retain the faculty-led coaching program and evaluate it as a targeted student-success intervention rather than cutting it prematurely as a remedial cost center. The strongest available evidence does not prove that counseling microskills coaching by itself causes higher graduation rates in master's counseling students. It does support the claim that individualized coaching and advising can improve persistence-related outcomes, and that faculty-led support plausibly targets mechanisms that matter in online graduate counseling education (Bettinger & Baker, 2014; Robbins et al., 2004).

The Administrative Dilemma: Visible Costs vs. Hidden Institutional Leakage

Visible Costs

- Specialized faculty and doctoral-level coach labor.
- Time-intensive sessions, coordination, and supervision.
- Dedicated support infrastructure that may appear expensive when viewed only as labor hours.

Hidden Institutional Leakage

- Tuition and fee revenue lost when students stop out before completion.
- Replacement costs associated with recruiting new students rather than retaining currently enrolled ones.
- Reputational and completion-rate costs when vulnerable students depart at preventable transition points.

Recruiting a new student typically costs substantially more than retaining an existing one, so even modest improvements in retention can offset meaningful portions of specialized support costs (Cuseo, 2010). The key administrative question is whether the program plausibly prevents enough stop-out to justify its footprint, not simply whether the support is helpful in a general sense.

Why This Population Is Vulnerable

Online, adult, and graduate learners face structural persistence risks that differ from those of traditional residential undergraduates. Online programs commonly report dropout rates in the 25 to 40% range, compared to roughly 10 to 20% for on-campus programs (Levy, 2007; Muljana

& Luo, 2019). Graduate attrition has been described as a hidden crisis, with roughly 30 to 50% of doctoral students never completing, most often departing during dissertation, clinical, or practicum stages (Lovitts & Nelson, 2000).

For counseling students, these risks intersect with CACREP (2024) gatekeeping requirements, supervision demands, and students' internalized professional identity. When early clinical performance goes poorly and no structured relational support is available, students may interpret the struggle as evidence that they do not belong in the field, triggering attrition or delayed progression (Friedlander et al., 1986).

What Drives Persistence for Online Adult Learners

Traditional retention theories often emphasized broad social integration as the primary driver of persistence. For online, adult, and nontraditional learners, the evidence is more nuanced. Environmental demands, academic utility, support quality, instructional clarity, self-efficacy, and perceived institutional care frequently carry equal or greater weight than generalized campus belonging (Bean & Metzner, 1985; Cabrera et al., 1992).

This distinction matters because faculty-led coaching is not best understood as a substitute for campus life. It is better understood as a targeted intervention that reduces ambiguity, increases instructional presence, strengthens self-efficacy, and communicates that the institution is concretely invested in each student's ability to continue (Tinto, 2012).

The Mattering Mechanism

Strayhorn's (2018) work on sense of belonging and Schlossberg's (1989) concept of mattering both establish that students persist when they feel noticed, supported, and important to specific institutional actors. In online settings, mattering may be especially actionable. Students may not feel broadly integrated into a virtual campus community, yet may remain enrolled because a specific faculty member provides credible evidence that their success matters (Boston et al., 2009; Garrison et al., 2000).

A coaching relationship operationalizes this form of mattering directly. When students receive real-time, individualized, non-evaluative support around feared performance tasks, the coaching interaction becomes a signal that the institution sees their struggle and expects their continuation.

Counseling-Specific Mechanisms

The Skills Enhancement Lab Cycle 1 data showed that students most often described the experience in terms of specific skill practice and feedback, reduced anxiety, hands-on learning, and increased confidence. Those findings are satisfaction and mechanism indicators rather than proof of long-term outcomes, but they align with established constructs in counselor development and training.

The counselor training literature supports the plausibility of these mechanisms. Trainee anxiety, role conflict, and self-efficacy matter during early clinical development, and structured feedback

can positively influence both confidence and distress during skill acquisition (Daniels & Larson, 2001; Friedlander et al., 1986). Deliberate practice frameworks further support the use of repeated rehearsal, immediate correction, and expert-guided refinement for counseling competency development (Ericsson, 2008; Irvine et al., 2024).

Weight of the Empirical Evidence

Tier 1: Strongly Supported

- A randomized trial of InsideTrack coaching found that coached students were approximately 5 percentage points more likely to persist in college at 6 to 12 months than comparable students without coaching (Bettinger & Baker, 2014). This is to date the most directly applicable RCT evidence for coaching-only effects on persistence.
- The CUNY Accelerated Study in Associate Programs (ASAP) randomized trial showed an 18 percentage point increase in 3-year graduation rates (Scrivener et al., 2015; Weiss et al., 2019). Critically, ASAP is a comprehensive, bundled support model that includes intensive advising, financial gap scholarships, transportation assistance, and structured scheduling. Its effect size reflects the full package, not coaching alone, and should not be cited as evidence that coaching by itself produces an 18-point graduation boost.
- The What Works Clearinghouse (2024) advising guide endorses comprehensive, integrated advising and coaching models as evidence-based strategies for improving credit accumulation and persistence.

Tier 2: Moderately Supported

- Meta-analyses across multiple fields find that mentoring and strong supervisor relationships are associated with higher retention and completion among graduate and professional students (Eby et al., 2008).
- A recent systematic scoping review of academic coaching in graduate healthcare and medical education found meaningful associations between structured coaching and academic and professional outcomes (Donaldson et al., 2025).
- Online persistence research repeatedly identifies support structures, instructor presence, communication, and connectedness as meaningful predictors of continuation (Walsh et al., 2024).

Tier 3: Limited but Promising

- Direct randomized evidence that faculty-led counseling microskills coaching improves graduation for master's counseling students does not yet exist.
- The strongest current argument is mechanism-based: coaching targets self-efficacy, anxiety reduction, mattering, task clarity, and persistence-relevant instructional connection that the broader literature treats as meaningful (Bandura, 1997; Robbins et al., 2004).

Reframing: From Remedial Cost Center to Student-Success Infrastructure

Old Paradigm: The coaching program is viewed as a reactive penalty for struggling students, evaluated purely by faculty labor hours, and framed as a pedagogical luxury the institution cannot afford.

New Paradigm: Coaching is a proactive, targeted student-success intervention for a structurally vulnerable online clinical training population. It is evaluated by its contribution to term-to-term persistence and progression, and it is integrated into the institution's broader retention strategy with an associated ROI analysis.

The institutional evaluation question is not "Is coaching nice to have?" It is "Does this specific coaching model prevent enough attrition among our online counseling students to justify its cost?"

The Local Testing Gap: What Must Be Established Here

Existing trials and reviews show that coaching and comprehensive advising can work in principle (Bettinger & Baker, 2014; Donaldson et al., 2025). The remaining question is whether this particular faculty-led coaching model yields measurable academic and financial returns at this university.

Target 1: Local Term-to-Term Persistence

Does participation in coaching predict higher re-enrollment and lower stop-out for online counseling students, after adjusting for baseline risk indicators?

Target 2: Dosage Threshold

Many advising and coaching studies suggest that repeated contacts matter more than one-off support before effects stabilize. The institution should determine its own local dosage threshold rather than claiming a specific number of sessions without local data.

Target 3: Financial ROI

What is the net tuition margin associated with retaining coached students compared to non-coached peers, after accounting for faculty compensation and administrative overhead? This calculation requires actual institutional financial data, not borrowed industry estimates.

Tiered Evaluation Framework

Tier 1: Proximal (Immediate Post-Session)

- Counseling self-efficacy, anxiety about clinical performance, sense of mattering, clarity of next steps, perceived usefulness.
- Method: 1 to 2 minute post-session Likert survey capturing immediate psychological mechanism indicators.

Tier 2: Medium-Term (Within-Term Academic Indicators)

- Course completion, term GPA, progression toward practicum prerequisites, repeat lab attendance.
- Method: LMS/SIS linkage comparing coached and non-coached students on academic indicators at term end.

Tier 3: Distal (Institutional Outcomes)

- Term-to-term persistence, stop-out patterns, time-to-degree, practicum and internship readiness.
- Method: Matched-sample historical analysis and, where feasible, quasi-experimental designs such as propensity-score matching.

Administrator Takeaways

- Maintain the program through a complete evaluation cycle rather than cutting it before local outcome testing is complete.
- Avoid overclaiming. Do not present comprehensive bundled intervention effects (e.g., ASAP) as if they were coaching-only effects (Scrivener et al., 2015).
- Use the program's strongest current case: it targets mechanisms the literature consistently associates with persistence and progression for vulnerable online learners (Bean & Metzner, 1985; Tinto, 2012).
- Build the institutional case with local data on mechanism activation, academic progression, persistence rates, and cost offset against actual labor and revenue figures.

Conclusion

Faculty-led skills coaching in online counseling education should be understood as a plausible and strategically important student-success intervention, not as a proven standalone graduation engine and not as a disposable remedial extra. The literature supports continuation, disciplined framing, and rigorous local testing. The institutional task is now to measure whether this specific program improves the outcomes it is theoretically and practically well-positioned to influence (Tinto, 2012; Bettinger & Baker, 2014; Donaldson et al., 2025).

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